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## A GUIDE FOR SERVICE BUSINESSES

# How to Shoot a Customer Testimonial on Your iPhone

*The complete guide — from the first phone call to the file your website plays*

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### READ THIS FIRST

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You can make a good customer testimonial on the phone in your pocket. This guide is the whole job, in order, with nothing left out: how to pick the customer and ask them, what to have them sign, what to ask on camera and why the obvious question fails, how to get clean sound in an ordinary room, how to frame and light one person, how much to shoot, and then everything that happens after the camera is off — the transcript, the selects, the cut, the captions, the music license, the color, the export for each place it will play, and the round of notes from your customer's boss.

It is written for one person, one phone, and one customer, making one film of about 60 to 90 seconds plus a couple of short cuts for social. Everything scales from there.

Two things before you start.

**The camera is not the hard part.** A current iPhone shoots better pictures than the cameras most of this industry used ten years ago. The parts that decide whether the finished film works are the questions, the sound, and the edit. This guide gives those the most room.

**Do the steps in order.** Each one sets up the next: the placement decides the shot, the room decides the sound, the transcript decides the cut. None of the steps is hard on its own.

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## PART ONE — BEFORE THE SHOOT

### 1. DECIDE WHAT THE FILM IS FOR

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Decide the placement before you decide anything else, because it determines length, shape, and how you frame the shot.

The places a testimonial actually earns for a service business, in rough order:

- **Your website**, on the page for the kind of work it shows (the commercial-roofing page, the implant page, the estate-planning page), not buried on a “testimonials” page nobody visits.
- **Your Google Business Profile**, which is where most people look at you before they call. Google’s own limit for profile videos is 30 seconds, so plan a 30-second cut from the start.
- **The estimate follow-up**. A link in the email you send after a quote, to the film of a customer just like the one deciding.
- **The sales conversation**. On your phone, shown to the next facilities manager or practice owner deciding between bids.
- **Social**, organically, to people who already follow you. Paid social to strangers is where testimonials do the least.

So the standard deliverable set is: one 60–90 second film in landscape (16:9), one 30-second cut for Google, and one vertical 9:16 cut for Reels/Shorts/TikTok. Decide now which of those you actually need. Each one you add is more edit time and more approval time. One good horizontal film and a 30-second cut is a complete project.

### 2. CHOOSE THE CUSTOMER, AND ASK THEM THE RIGHT WAY

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**Who.** The best subject is the person who was happiest on the day the job finished, who has some standing in their own world (the office manager at the dental practice, the plant manager, the owner of the restaurant, the executive director of the nonprofit), and who talks in sentences. Enthusiasm matters less than specificity: the homeowner who remembers that your crew left the driveway cleaner than they found it is worth more on camera than the one who says you were “amazing.”

Your existing reviews are the shortlist. Read them and pull out the five people who wrote a detail, not an adjective.

**How to ask.** Call, don’t email. Say what it is, how long it takes, and where it will be seen:

*“We’re putting together a short video about [the project]. It’s you talking for about twenty minutes, I ask questions, and it becomes a minute or so. It would go on our website and Google page. No script — I just want you to say what you’d say to someone who asked you about the job. Would you be up for it?”*

Then follow up in writing with the date, the time, the place, roughly what you’ll ask about (topics, not questions — see section 5), what to wear, and the release attached.

**Never pay for it.** Not money, not a discount, not a gift. Since October 2024 the FTC's rule on consumer reviews and testimonials (16 CFR Part 465) treats compensation for a testimonial that isn't disclosed as a violation, and treats testimonials by people who didn't actually have the experience as fake. The value of the film is that it's true. A thank-you card after the fact is fine. A discount before is not.

**If the customer works for an organization** — a medical practice, a school, a company, a nonprofit — find out now who else has to say yes. An office manager may need the owner; a facilities manager needs someone above them; a nonprofit's executive director may want the board chair to know. Get that yes before the shoot, not after. Section 22 covers the approval round.

### 3. THE RELEASE

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Get it signed before the camera rolls. Everyone means to do it after; after is when people are busy and the email goes unanswered.

We're not lawyers and this isn't legal advice; a simple appearance release is a common one-page document, templates are easy to find, and a quick look from your attorney is cheap. What yours should cover:

- **Who** is granting it (name, organization, title as they want it shown).
- **What** — their name, likeness, voice, and the words they say in the recording made on that date.
- **Where and how long** — your website, social channels, Google profile, sales materials, advertising; perpetual; worldwide. Name the uses you might actually want. Boosting a post is advertising — include it.
- **Editing** — you may edit, shorten, and combine the footage; they won't have approval over the final cut (see section 22 on why you'll show it to them anyway).
- **No compensation** — stated plainly, for the reason in section 2.
- **Organization consent**, if they're speaking for one: a line where the organization (through whoever can bind it) consents to being identified and to the footage of its premises.
- Signature, date, contact.

Also think about:

- **Location.** If you're filming inside their building, you need their permission for the building, not just the person. The organization line covers it.
- **Other people.** Anyone recognizable in your b-roll — diners, patients in a waiting room, staff, kids — either signs, is shot from behind or out of focus, or isn't in the film. Children require a parent's signature; most people just don't film them.
- **Their logo and name on screen.** Covered by the organization consent.
- **Your own crew's photos.** If a photographer or drone operator shot the before pictures, check that you have the right to use their material in a film. A photo license for the website is not automatically a license for video.

E-signature is fine. Keep the signed copy with the project files forever — section 22's approval email goes in the same folder.

## 4. QUESTION ARCHITECTURE — WHAT TO ASK, AND WHY THE OBVIOUS QUESTION FAILS

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This is the section that decides the film.

**Why “tell us about your experience” fails.** It asks for a summary. People answer a summary question with a summary: “It was great. They were professional, on time, the price was fair, I’d recommend them.” Every word is true and none of it is usable. A stranger has heard that exact sentence a thousand times about a thousand companies; it carries no information and no belief. The customer has done nothing wrong — you asked for a verdict and got one.

What you need instead is **moments**. Specifics that only this person, about this job, could say. “I walked in on Monday morning and the pews were back exactly where they’d been. I hadn’t even asked.” That sentence sells a painting company to every church in the region. For an accounting firm the moment is “She called me about the notice before I’d even opened the envelope.” For an HVAC company it’s “They were in my attic at seven in the morning on the Fourth of July.” Every one of them comes from asking about a moment, not an opinion.

### The five rules:

1. **Ask for moments, not opinions.** “What did you see when you walked in?” not “How was the result?”
2. **Ask before/after questions.** The film has a shape: there was a problem, something was decided, the work happened, something is different now. Your questions walk that path in order.
3. **Ask for numbers, names, and days.** “How long had you been putting it off?” “How many customers came through that first weekend?”
4. **Ask the same thing twice, differently.** The second answer is usually the one you use; they’ve warmed up and found the words.
5. **Have them include your question in their answer.** You won’t be in the film. “We chose them because...” works alone. “Because they were local” does not. Tell them this once at the start and remind them gently when they forget.

**The question set.** Use this as the spine and rewrite it in your own words for the job:

#### *The situation before*

1. Tell me about the place — the business, the building, the department we worked on. Who uses it, and what does it mean to people?
2. What was the condition of it before? What did it look like — what were people saying?
3. How long had this been on the list? What kept it from getting done?

#### *The deciding*

4. When you started looking, what were you worried about? (This is where the real objections live — mess, disruption, price, trust — and where the customer answers them for you.)
5. How did you find us? What made you pick up the phone?
6. What made you decide to go with us over someone else?

### *The work*

7. Walk me through the first day. What did you see?
8. Was there a moment during the job when you thought, “OK, these are the right people”?
9. Did anything go wrong, and what happened when it did? (Ask this. An honest answer about a problem handled well is the most believable sentence in any testimonial.)
10. What surprised you?

### *The result*

11. Describe the first time you walked in after it was done.
12. What did other people say — staff, customers, patients, your board, your spouse?
13. What’s different now, day to day?

### *The recommendation*

14. If a friend who runs a similar business called you tonight and asked about us, what would you tell them?
15. Who should not hire us? (Sounds odd; produces the most trusted lines. “If you want the cheapest bid, that’s not them. If you want it done once...”)
16. Anything I should have asked and didn’t?

**The follow-ups** that matter more than the questions: “Say more about that.” “Can you give me an example?” “What did that look like?” And silence — count to four after they finish before you speak. The best sentence is often the one after the pause.

**The second take.** When they say something good but long, ask for it again: “That was great. Say it again for me, shorter — start with ‘The thing I noticed...’” Non-actors do this well. It’s not scripting; it’s the same person saying their own thought a second time.

**What you’re listening for:** one complete sentence, in their words, that a stranger would believe. Eight to twelve of those is a film. When you have them, you’re done; keep going anyway for another ten minutes because the last question often produces the first line.

## 5. GETTING A NERVOUS NON-ACTOR TO SPEAK IN COMPLETE THOUGHTS

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Most people have never been interviewed on camera. They’ll be stiff for the first five minutes. That’s normal, and it’s yours to manage.

- **Give them topics, not questions, in advance.** If they see the exact questions they’ll write answers, memorize them, and deliver them like a hostage. Tell them the areas — “how it was before, why you chose us, how it went, how it is now” — and nothing more.
- **Tell them three things at the start, out loud:** it’s not live; mistakes cost nothing because you’ll cut; and they can stop, restart, or say a thing three times. Nervous people relax when they know they can’t ruin it.

- **Start with questions you'll never use.** “How long have you been here? What’s a normal Tuesday like?” Three minutes of that and they forget the phone.
- **One interviewer, no audience.** Their boss, their spouse, your business partner — out of the room. People perform for an audience and talk to a person.
- **Sit right next to the lens, at their eye level, and look at them.** Never at your notes, never at the phone screen. Your face is what they’re talking to.
- **Nod, don’t talk.** Every “mm-hm” and “right” you say lands on the recording under their best sentence. Agree with your face.
- **Don’t correct them.** If they get your company name wrong, ask the question again later.
- **Keep the interview to about twenty or thirty minutes.** After that people tire and the answers get shorter and vaguer.
- **Don’t script. Ever.** If you write lines and they read them, the film is an ad, the customer knows it, and everyone who watches it knows it. Questions only.

## 6. THE LOCATION — WHAT A ROOM DOES TO SOUND

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Sound is set by the room before you plug anything in, so choose the room for the sound and fix the picture afterward.

**Hard, bare rooms echo.** A sanctuary, a gym, a lobby, a conference room with a glass wall and a bare table — every one of them puts a ring on the voice that no software fully removes. **Soft rooms are quiet.** An office with carpet, books, curtains, and a couch. A living room. A small room with stuff in it.

**The clap test.** Stand where they’ll sit and clap once. If you hear a tail after the clap, the room will ring. Try another room, or bring soft things in: a rug on the floor, moving blankets over a chair behind the camera, a couch pulled into the shot’s blind side.

**The hum.** Listen for what’s always on: HVAC, a refrigerator, a fish tank, a server closet, traffic, a road, a playground. Turn off what you can — the thermostat for the length of the interview, the fridge (put your car keys inside it so you remember to turn it back on). What you can’t turn off, get away from: move to the far side of the building from the road, close the door.

**The trade-off you’ll face.** The finished work — the sanctuary you just painted, the dining room you re-floored, the warehouse you re-wired — is usually the worst-sounding room in the building. Two good answers: interview in the quiet office and shoot the finished space as b-roll (the film will cut between them and nobody will mind), or interview in the space with the microphone close (section 7) and accept a little more room in the sound. The wrong answer is the big room with the phone’s built-in microphone from six feet away.

**Depth.** Pick a spot with room behind the subject — eight feet or more to the back wall if you can get it. It separates them from the background and it looks like a film instead of a passport photo.

**Time of day** matters for light (section 10) and for noise: school pickup, lunch rush, the lawn crew. Ask what’s scheduled.

## 7. AUDIO — THE PART THAT ACTUALLY BREAKS IT

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Viewers forgive a soft picture. They will not sit through a voice they have to work to hear. So sound gets the most care of anything on the shoot — and it comes down to three moves: a microphone close to the mouth, a level you can see, and headphones on.

**The built-in microphone is for b-roll, not for the interview.** It's fine for the ambient sound of a room or a crew working. For a voice it is too far away, and it picks up the room more than the person.

**What to buy.** A wireless lavalier kit: a small transmitter with a clip-on microphone that goes on the customer, and a receiver that plugs into the phone. We recommend the **DJI Mic 3**; the equivalent from Rode is the **Rode Wireless GO (Gen 3)**. Either is a one-time purchase that will outlast several phones. The DJI Mic 3's receiver connects to an iPhone through the USB-C phone adapter that comes in the box, so an iPhone 15 or newer plugs straight in; an older iPhone with a Lightning port needs a Lightning adapter, which DJI no longer includes and which you buy separately. It can also pair with the phone over Bluetooth — but for an interview, use the receiver on the port, because that is what makes the headphone monitoring below work. Whichever kit you choose, make sure the transmitter records a backup copy on itself; it is the feature that saves an interview. Charge everything the night before.

**Where to put it.** Clip the microphone about a hand's width below the chin, centered on the chest, on a lapel, collar, or the placket of a shirt. Not on a loose sweater (rustle), not under a jacket flap that swings, not next to a necklace or lanyard. If the kit has a separate clip-on capsule on a cable, run the cable inside the clothing; if the transmitter itself is the microphone, use the magnet or clip so nothing brushes it when they move. If the top layer is a problem, a small piece of tape holds it where you want it. Have them say a sentence and watch for anything that rubs.

**Set the level.** The phone's own Camera app doesn't show you audio levels, which means you'd be recording blind. Use a camera app that does — Blackmagic Camera (free) is the standard recommendation; it also gives you the exposure and focus controls you'll want in section 8. Have the customer talk in their normal voice and set the level so the meter peaks around -12 dB and never touches the top. Too low is fixable; distortion at the top is not.

**Wear headphones, and listen while you record.** The DJI Mic 3's receiver has a dedicated 3.5 mm headphone jack for real-time monitoring. Plug wired headphones into it and keep them on for the whole interview. You'll hear the rustle, the buzz, the truck outside, as it happens, while it can still be fixed. Then do a test: record thirty seconds of the customer answering a warm-up question, play it back through the headphones, and only then start the real thing.

**Airplane mode.** A phone call or a text in the middle of the best answer ends the take. Put the recording phone in airplane mode (Bluetooth can stay on if your mic needs it). Ask the customer to silence theirs too.

**Room tone.** Before you pack up, record 30 seconds of the room with nobody talking. You'll use it in the edit to fill gaps so the cuts don't sound like cuts.

**A backup.** Turn on the transmitter's onboard recording; it runs the whole time regardless of what the phone does. If your kit doesn't have it, a second phone running Voice Memos in the customer's shirt pocket is a real backup that costs nothing.

## 8. CAMERA SETTINGS

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Set the phone once, before the customer arrives, and don't touch it again.

- **Resolution and frame rate: 4K at 30 fps** for anything that will live on the web and social. (24 fps looks more like film; 30 matches the way social platforms and screens play back. Pick one and use the same one for every clip on the shoot, interview and b-roll alike — mixing them makes the edit stutter.) 4K gives you room to crop later, including a vertical crop for Reels.
- **HDR Video: OFF.** Settings > Camera > Record Video > HDR Video. On by default, it produces footage that looks washed-out or over-bright on many screens and in most editing software, and it's the most common reason self-shot iPhone video looks "wrong" once it leaves the phone. Turn it off for this job.
- **Format: Most Compatible** (Settings > Camera > Formats) unless you're short on space. High Efficiency (HEVC) files are half the size and every modern editor reads them, but "Most Compatible" removes one variable.
- **Storage.** The settings screen prints how much space each mode uses per minute — roughly 170 MB per minute for 4K at 30 fps in High Efficiency, about double in Most Compatible. The interview plus the b-roll in section 11 comes to 10–20 GB; clear at least 30 GB before the day. If your phone uses iCloud's "Optimize iPhone Storage," be aware the full-resolution files may not stay on the phone; section 13 covers getting them off properly.
- **Lens: the main 1× camera.** It has the best sensor. Move the tripod instead of zooming; the ultra-wide (0.5×) distorts faces and the digital zoom throws away resolution. On Pro models, the 2× setting is a crop of the main sensor and is fine for a tighter second angle.
- **Lock exposure, focus, and white balance.** In the native app, press and hold on the customer's face until "AE/AF LOCK" appears. In Blackmagic Camera, lock all three explicitly. If you don't, the phone will hunt every time they move and the picture will pulse.
- **Shutter.** If your app lets you set it, 1/60 at 30 fps (1/50 at 24). It's what makes motion look natural.
- **Orientation: landscape (horizontal)** for the interview, even if a vertical cut is the goal. A 4K horizontal frame contains a full-quality 1080×1920 vertical crop; the reverse isn't true. If vertical is the primary deliverable and you're shooting two angles, the second phone can shoot vertical.
- **Tripod.** A small tripod and a phone clamp — \$25–50 — is non-negotiable for the interview. Handheld interviews drift; a still frame is what makes it feel deliberate.
- **Lock Camera and Lock White Balance.** Two switches under Settings > Camera > Record Video on recent iPhones. *Lock Camera* stops the phone from switching lenses mid-recording; *Lock White Balance* holds the color where it was when you pressed record. Turn both on for this job.
- **Power and heat.** Plug the phone in. A long 4K recording in a warm room or direct sun can overheat the phone and pause the recording; keep it shaded and out of the sun.
- **Do Not Disturb** on, notifications off.

## 9. FRAMING AND EYELINE

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**Camera at their eye level.** Not above (diminishing), not below (looming). Raise the tripod until the lens is level with their eyes when they're sitting.

**The interviewer sits beside the lens.** Your head about a foot to one side of the phone, at the same height, close. The customer looks at you, which means their eyes land just off the lens — the standard documentary eyeline. If you sit far to the side they'll be in profile; if you have them look into the lens they'll stiffen and it will look like a hostage video.

**The shot.** A medium shot: bottom of the frame around mid-chest, top of the frame a little above the head — small headroom, not a hat's worth. Put them slightly off-center, with the empty side of the frame on the side they're looking toward. That's all the rule of thirds means here.

**Background.** The finished work if it reads at that distance; otherwise something with depth and not much going on. Avoid: a window behind them (they'll be a silhouette), a bright lamp, a bare wall right behind them, anything that looks like it's growing out of their head, a clock, a screen, a mirror.

**Two angles, or one.** We highly recommend two angles. Every edit inside the interview is a visible jump on the customer's face, and cutting to a second angle is the cleanest way to make those edits disappear — the film reads as a conversation, not a series of cuts. That said, social media has normalized the single-camera “punch-in” style, where the picture simply jumps tighter on the same person, and a second angle is nowhere near as critical as it once was. Both routes work. Here is how to do each properly.

*Two phones.* Borrow one. Put the second phone on its own tripod and clamp, on the same side of the main camera as you, the interviewer, are sitting — just outside your shoulder — so the customer's eyes land between the two lenses and both angles read as “talking to someone just off camera.” Keep it within about 20–30 degrees of the main camera; further round and you're into their profile. Same height: lens at their eye level. Tighter framing: where the main camera holds mid-chest up, the second holds shoulders up — the 2× setting on a Pro, or simply a foot or two closer. Same settings on both: 4K, 30 fps, HDR off, exposure and white balance locked, focus locked on the face. If the phones are different models, plan to match the color in the edit (section 20). Start both recording, then clap once, loudly, where both cameras can see your hands; in the edit you line the two clips up on that clap (most editors will also sync them automatically by their audio). The microphone feeds one phone; the other phone's own audio is only there for sync. And never let the second camera cross to the far side of the customer — both cameras stay on your side of the line between you and them, or the two angles will look like they're facing opposite directions.

*One phone, punching in.* Shoot 4K and plan to deliver at 1080, which leaves you room to crop in the edit without losing sharpness. Frame a touch looser than you otherwise would — mid-chest with a little more air — and keep the customer's face on the same third of the frame the whole way through, so the punch-in lands in the same place every time. Lock focus on the face, because a soft frame gets softer when it's enlarged. In the edit, alternate between the full frame and a punch-in of about 1.2× to 1.5× — enough to read as a second shot, not so much that it looks like a zoom — and make the change on a sentence break, never mid-thought. Keep the punch-ins under about 2× (the point at which a 4K frame stops being full resolution at 1080), and save them for the emotional lines: the punch-in is your close-up.

**Wardrobe.** Tell them in the confirmation email: solid colors in the middle of the range; no fine stripes, checks, or small patterns (they shimmer on video); no big logos other than their own organization's; nothing pure white or pure black if they can help it; nothing that jingles. What they'd wear to a meeting is right.

**Seating.** A chair without wheels or a swivel, without arms if possible, that doesn't rock. A stool works. Not a couch — people sink and slump.

## 10. LIGHT

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You don't need lights. You need to put the person in the right place relative to the light that's there.

**Window light from the side-front.** Face the customer toward a window at roughly 45 degrees, with the camera between them and the window. The lit side of their face is toward the camera, the other side falls off gently. This is the whole recipe for a good-looking interview and it costs nothing.

**Never the window behind them.** The phone exposes for the bright window and the face goes dark, or it exposes for the face and the window blows out to white. Either way it's a silhouette.

**Watch the sun.** Direct sun through a window is hard, moves, and changes in twenty minutes; halfway through the interview the shot won't match the beginning. Use a window the sun isn't coming through directly (north-facing windows are steady all day), or hang a sheer curtain or a white bedsheet over the window to soften it. Overcast days are a gift.

**Turn off the overhead lights.** Fluorescent and mixed LED ceiling light is greenish, comes from above, and puts shadows in the eye sockets. If you must use them, at least don't mix them with window light — pick one.

**If the room has no usable window,** a single small LED panel — \$40–100, battery, dimmable, ideally with adjustable color temperature — set at the same 45-degree position and above eye height does the job. Bounce a piece of white foam board or a white poster board on the dark side to soften the shadow. That's a complete two-point setup.

**Expose for the face.** With exposure locked (section 8), the face should look like a face — not glowing, not muddy. Let the background do what it does.

**Lock white balance** so the color doesn't drift when a cloud passes. If skin looks orange or blue on the screen, fix it now, not in the edit.

## 11. HOW MUCH FOOTAGE IS ENOUGH

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More than feels reasonable. A 90-second film comes from a 20–30 minute interview; that ratio is normal, not wasteful.

**Interview:** the full question set, the follow-ups, second takes on the three or four best answers, and the last “anything I didn't ask.” Don't stop when you think you have it. Don't stop when the customer thinks you have it either — “I think that's probably enough” is when you say “two more.”

**B-roll — the pictures that go over the words.** This is what makes the film look like a film and what hides your edits. Aim for 25–40 clips, each held still for at least ten seconds, on the tripod or braced against something. Whatever the

business, the b-roll is the same four things — **hands doing the work, the tools, the finished result, and the people served** — plus the place itself. Apply the pattern to your own trade; here is what it looks like across a few.

- **Hands doing the work.** A painter's brush cutting a clean line along the trim. A technician's hands on the HVAC unit, the panel open, a gauge being read. A hygienist setting up the tray. An accountant walking a client through a document, finger on the line that matters. A cook plating at the pass. Shoot the hands, not the face; ten seconds each; these are the shots that cover your edits.
- **The tools.** The crew loading the truck in the morning. Drop cloths going down. The toolbag open on the floor. The sterilized instruments in their sleeve. The binder, the calculator, the second monitor. The van with your name on it pulling up. Work being done carefully, in the order it's actually done.
- **The finished result,** at three sizes: wide, medium, close. The painted room, then one wall, then the cut line where the new color meets the trim. The house from the street, the ridge, a hand on a new shingle. The new unit on its pad and the thermostat reading the right number. The patient's smile in the hand mirror. The signed document on the desk. The dining room full, the new floor under the tables.
- **The people served.** The customer walking in, looking at the work, touching it, doing what they normally do there — greeting a patient, unlocking the door, pouring the first coffee. The restaurant line at service. Someone walking a client to the door. Not looking at the camera; if anyone recognizable is in the shot, section 3 applies.
- **The place.** The building from outside, the sign, the door, the parking lot with cars in it, the street it's on. One of these opens the film.
- **The before,** if it exists — photos or clips you have the right to use (section 3). A single before shot, held for three seconds ahead of the after, does more than a paragraph of talking.

Shoot for the film you'll cut: for every sentence in the paper edit you expect to cover, you want at least one picture that shows what the sentence says.

Shoot b-roll at the same resolution and frame rate as the interview. Static shots cut better than moves; if you want movement, a slow, steady walk with the phone held in both hands is enough. No whip pans, no zooms. If you want a slow-motion shot of something, that's 60 fps at 1080 and one or two clips, not a style.

**Photos.** Take a few stills of the customer and the space with the phone. You'll want one for the thumbnail (section 21) and the website.

## 12. SHOOT DAY — RUN OF SHOW

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- **Arrive early — 45 minutes is right.** Find the room, do the clap test, kill the hum, place the chair, set the tripod, frame, light, lock the settings, mic yourself and test the level on your own voice.
- **Greet them without the phone in your hand.** Five minutes of ordinary conversation.
- **Mic them, sit down, say the three things** (not live; mistakes are free; you can say it again). Remind them to include the question in the answer. Press record on every camera, clap once if there are two, and start with the warm-up.
- **The interview.** The question set, the follow-ups, second takes on the best three, the last question.

- **Room tone.** 30 seconds, quiet, before you unclip the mic.
  - **B-roll.** The list in section 11, with the customer for some of it if they'll stay.
  - **Thank them, confirm the spelling of their name and title on paper,** tell them when they'll see it (section 22), and leave.
  - **Back up before you drive away** (section 13). A phone is one device with everything on it.
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## PART TWO — AFTER THE SHOOT

This is the half that turns footage into a film. It gets the same care as the shoot, in the same order, and each step here is as concrete as the ones above.

### 13. BACKUP AND INGEST

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**Two copies, on two devices, before you delete anything from the phone.** Computer plus external drive; computer plus cloud; two drives. Not “it’s on the phone and iCloud” — that’s one copy with a sync.

**Get the full-resolution files.** Plug the phone in with a cable and copy the originals (on a Mac: Image Capture, or Photos > import, or the Files app if the camera app saved there). AirDrop works for a handful of clips and is painfully slow for 15 GB. If you had iCloud “Optimize iPhone Storage” on, some clips may be low-resolution stand-ins on the phone; download the originals from iCloud on the computer.

**Name and file it.** One folder for the project, with inside it: *01\_originals* (never edited, never renamed), *02\_audio* (the wireless backup recording, the Voice Memo), *03\_project* (the edit), *04\_exports*, *05\_paperwork* (the release, the approval email, the music license). Copy the originals in and don’t touch that folder again.

**Check every clip opens** on the computer and plays with sound before you leave the phone alone.

### 14. TRANSCRIBE AND LOG

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Don’t start cutting. Start reading.

**Transcribe the interview.** On a Mac, MacWhisper transcribes a file for free; Descript and CapCut do it too; the paid editors (Premiere, and the Studio version of DaVinci Resolve) have it built in. Whichever you use, you want a transcript with timestamps, so every sentence points back to its place in the footage.

**Read it with a highlighter, twice.** First pass: mark every sentence that is (a) specific to this job, (b) something a stranger would believe, and (c) complete on its own — no “it” without an antecedent, no half-thought. Ignore anything that’s only adjectives. Second pass: of the marked sentences, find the ones that do a job in the story — the before, the worry, the decision, the moment during, the result, the recommendation.

**Build the paper edit.** In a document, put the chosen sentences in story order with their timestamps. That’s your film, in words. Read it aloud and time it. People speak at roughly 140–160 words a minute in conversation, so a 90-second film is about 200–230 spoken words — usually 8 to 12 sentences. If the paper edit runs long, cut sentences, not words within them.

A paper edit that reads well makes the cut mechanical; skipping it makes the cut a search.

## 15. SELECTING — THE STANDARD

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The lines that make it in:

- **Concrete beats general.** “She called me before the letter even arrived” beats “she’s very responsive.”
- **One idea per sentence.** A line that does two things gets cut in half or dropped.
- **The problem line stays.** The honest sentence about the thing that went wrong and got fixed is the most believed line in the film. Don’t lose your nerve.
- **Face for feeling, b-roll for facts.** Plan to be on the customer’s face for the lines that carry emotion or a recommendation, and over b-roll for the lines that carry information.
- **Nothing they’d regret.** If a sentence could embarrass the customer, their organization, or a third party — “the last company we hired was a disaster,” “they were the cheapest” — think about whether it survives section 22. Usually cut it now.
- **Their words.** Never re-order words within a sentence to make a new sentence. Cutting between sentences is editing; cutting inside them is putting words in someone’s mouth.

The shape of a 90-second testimonial, roughly: open on a strong specific line or the situation (5–10 seconds) → the worry and the decision (20 seconds) → the work, with the problem-handled line (25 seconds) → the result (20 seconds) → the recommendation, on their face (10–15 seconds) → your logo, website, phone (4–5 seconds).

## 16. CUTTING

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**Software, honestly.** iMovie is free, on your Mac already, and can make this film. CapCut is free and fast, and its built-in music library is not licensed for business use (section 19). DaVinci Resolve is free, is a full professional editor, and has a real learning curve — worth it if you’ll do this more than twice. Final Cut Pro and Premiere are paid and no better for this job than Resolve.

**Assembly.** Lay the selected sentences on the timeline in paper-edit order, trimming each to the breath before and after. Watch it once without b-roll. If the story works as a string of talking-head clips, you’re most of the way there. If it doesn’t, the fix is in the selects, not the pictures — go back to section 14.

**The jump cuts.** Every place two sentences meet is a visible jump on the customer’s face. Three ways to handle it, in order of preference:

1. **Cut to the second angle** for the next sentence. Invisible and natural.
2. **Cover the cut with b-roll** — the picture goes to the finished wall while the voice keeps talking, and you come back to the face on a new sentence.
3. **Leave the jump.** It’s a style on social. On a website film it reads as an edit, which is fine in moderation.

Don’t use a crossfade to hide a jump on a face. It looks like a ghost.

**Pace.** Let the first sentence breathe — a half second of them before they speak. Don’t butt every sentence against the next; the pauses are where a viewer believes them. End on their face, not on b-roll.

**Sound.** In this order:

- **Level the voice.** Every sentence at the same loudness. Editors have an “auto level” or “normalize”; use it, then listen and fix the outliers by hand.
- **Fill the gaps with room tone** (section 7) so the background doesn’t drop to silence at every cut.
- **Light noise reduction only if you need it.** iMovie and CapCut both have a one-switch noise reduction (in DaVinci Resolve it’s a Studio feature). A little is invisible; a lot makes the voice sound underwater. If you find yourself needing a lot, try the backup recording from section 7 first — it’s often the cleaner track.
- **Roll off the bottom.** A high-pass filter around 80–100 Hz removes room rumble and HVAC without touching the voice.
- **Music under, not over.** If you use music (section 19), it sits where you notice it only when it stops. Duck it under every line of speech.
- **Overall loudness for the web:** aim for about –14 LUFS integrated, peaks no higher than –1 dB. Every editor can show you these numbers; the platforms will turn you down to that anyway, and hitting it yourself means it plays at the level you intended.

## 17. TITLES AND LOWER THIRDS

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- **Name, title, organization** on screen the first time they appear, for 4–5 seconds, in a clean sans-serif big enough to read on a phone. Confirm the spelling and the title in writing with the customer before you type it. Titles are the most common note from an organization.
- **Your closing card:** logo, website, phone, 4–5 seconds, on a plain background. That’s the only place your company describes itself; the customer did the rest.
- **Keep text inside the safe area.** On vertical social cuts, the platform’s own interface covers the bottom 20 percent and the right edge of the screen. Keep names and captions in the middle 60 percent of the frame vertically, and away from the right edge.
- **Match the look across all your films.** Same font, same position, same color. This is what a “brand package” means — a lower-third template and a logo animation you reuse.

## 18. CAPTIONS

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Most social video is watched with the sound off, and a good share of website video is too. Captions are not optional.

- **Two kinds.** *Burned-in* (open) captions are part of the picture — they play everywhere and can’t be turned off. *Sidecar* (closed) captions are a separate file (SRT is the universal one) that a platform or website player shows as a toggle. Deliver both: burned-in for social cuts, SRT alongside the website/YouTube film.
- **Correct every word.** Auto-captions get names, company names, and trade terms wrong. Read through with the audio on.
- **Two lines maximum, about 32 characters per line, each caption on screen for at least a second.** Break at natural phrase boundaries, not mid-thought.

- **Legibility.** White text with a thin dark outline or a semi-transparent box behind it; no thin fonts; no yellow.
- **Placement.** Lower third of the frame, inside the safe area, and not on top of the name card when it's up — move the caption up for those seconds.
- **Accessibility.** If the film is on your website, a caption file is what makes it usable for people who can't hear it, and it's what accessibility standards expect. If you serve public institutions, this matters to them.

## 19. MUSIC RIGHTS — THE TRAP

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This is the mistake that costs the most and is the easiest to avoid.

- **No commercial songs.** Not from Spotify, not from a YouTube rip, not the one the customer loves. On a business account it's commercial use of copyrighted music; the platforms detect it automatically and will mute the video, block it, or take it down — sometimes months later, after it's been shared everywhere. On your website you're simply infringing.
- **In-app music is licensed for that app, personally.** The tracks inside Instagram, TikTok, and CapCut are licensed for personal use on that platform. Business accounts see a restricted library for exactly this reason, and none of it can be exported into the website version of the film.
- **"Royalty-free" still has terms.** YouTube's Audio Library is free for YouTube; some tracks require attribution; none of it is automatically cleared for your website or a boosted post. Read the license for each track.
- **The clean route: a subscription license** from a music library built for this (Epidemic Sound, Artlist, Soundstripe, Musicbed and others; roughly \$10–30 a month). Choose the *business* or *commercial* tier, not the personal one, and check that it covers every channel you'll use — web, social, paid/boosted posts, trade-show screens. Download the license certificate for the track and put it in *05\_paperwork*. If you cancel the subscription, videos already published are usually still covered; check the terms.
- **Or no music.** A well-recorded voice over room tone reads as honest and a lot of good testimonials use nothing else. If music is causing a problem, cut it.

Same rules for sound effects.

## 20. COLOR

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Keep it simple and keep it consistent.

- **If HDR was on** (section 8), this is where it bites: the footage will look flat, milky, or neon depending on the editor. Most editors can convert it to standard color on import; do that first, or set the project to SDR/Rec.709 and let the software convert.
- **Match the angles.** If you shot two phones, or the b-roll in a different room, make them look like the same day: white balance, then exposure, then contrast.
- **The basic correction, in order:** white balance until white things are white and skin is skin-colored; exposure so the face sits in the middle of the range; a touch of contrast; leave it. Skin should look like the person. No heavy looks, no filters, no "cinematic" LUTs.

- **Export in standard color (Rec.709, SDR)** so it looks the same on every screen.
- **Check on a phone and on a laptop.** They differ; the film should look right on both.

## 21. DELIVERABLE SPECS PER PLATFORM

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Make one **master** first: the finished film at 4K (or 1080p if that's what you shot), high bitrate, with the audio mixed, captions as a separate SRT, no burned-in captions. Every other version is derived from it. Then export per destination. Platform specs move; these were checked in September 2026 against the platforms' own help pages, and the places to re-check are named.

- **Master.** MP4, H.264 (or ProRes 422 if your editor offers it), 3840×2160 or 1920×1080, same frame rate you shot, AAC audio 48 kHz stereo. Keep it forever.
- **Website / YouTube / Vimeo (16:9, 60–120 s).** MP4, H.264, 1920×1080 at 8 Mbps for 30 fps (12 Mbps at 60), or 4K at 35–45 Mbps; AAC 48 kHz, 384 kbps stereo. These are YouTube's own recommended upload settings. Upload the SRT as closed captions. Host on YouTube (unlisted is fine) or Vimeo and embed, rather than self-hosting the file — it plays reliably on every device and lets you set a **poster frame**: the customer, mid-sentence, eyes open, in the finished space. That frame is what most people will ever see, so choose it deliberately; a still from section 11 works too.
- **Google Business Profile (30 s).** Google's stated limits: up to 30 seconds, up to 75 MB, 720p or higher. So: a 30-second cut, 1920×1080, H.264, bitrate low enough to land under 75 MB (about 15 Mbps or less). One strong line, the result, the recommendation, the logo. Re-check: Google's "Photo and video guidelines" help page.
- **Instagram Reels / Facebook Reels / TikTok / YouTube Shorts (9:16).** 1080×1920, MP4, H.264, 30 fps, burned-in captions inside the safe area, 30–60 seconds. YouTube Shorts accepts up to three minutes; Instagram takes longer Reels but doesn't surface them the same way, and a testimonial has no business being that long anyway. Re-check each platform's current help page before a campaign; they change lengths yearly.
- **Instagram / Facebook feed (4:5 or 1:1).** 1080×1350 or 1080×1080, same file rules. Optional — the 9:16 cut covers most of it.
- **LinkedIn (16:9 or 1:1, under 2 min).** Native upload — the file itself, not a YouTube link, which LinkedIn treats as a link post. MP4, 1920×1080. Upload the SRT as captions or burn them in. Re-check LinkedIn's "video posts" help page for current limits.
- **Email / estimate follow-up.** Never attach the file. A thumbnail image (the poster frame, with or without a play button drawn on it) that links to the hosted film. Email clients don't play video.
- **In person / trade show / lobby screen.** The 1080p master with captions burned in. If it loops on a screen with no audio, captions carry the whole thing — consider a version with slightly larger caption text.

For every export: same frame rate as the shoot, loudness around –14 LUFS, and a filename that says what it is — *CompanyName\_CustomerTestimonial\_v3\_16x9\_1080p.mp4*. Watch every export all the way through on the device it's for before you send it anywhere.

## 22. THE REVISION ROUND WITH THE CUSTOMER'S BOSS

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You showed the customer a rough cut? Good. Now their organization has notes. This round is not a formality and it's not optional: it's their face, their name, and their building, and the film is only worth anything if they're glad it exists.

**Plan for one round, and give it a date.** The person who needs to approve it has a job that isn't this, so the ask carries a deadline, and the deadline is the approval if nobody replies.

**Send a private link, not a file.** An unlisted YouTube or Vimeo link, or a review link from a tool built for it (Frame.io has a free tier that lets people comment on the exact frame). Ask a specific question with a date:

*"Here's the cut. Is anything factually wrong, and is there anything you or [the organization] would be uncomfortable with? If I don't hear back by [date] I'll take it as approved. Thanks again for doing this."*

Not "what do you think?" — that invites creative notes on your film. You're asking for accuracy and comfort.

**What the notes usually are.** In rough order of frequency: the title or the spelling of the name; "our logo is the old one"; "can you take out the line about [price / the other company / the thing that went wrong]"; "there's a person in the background we can't show"; "the practice owner would like to add a sentence about the staff." Most of these are a quick fix. Removing a sentence that was load-bearing in the story means going back to the paper edit and finding a replacement line. That's why you didn't stop the interview early.

**Who gets the last word.** Decide before you send it. A workable rule: they own the facts and their own comfort; you own the film. If a note is "we don't like the music," you can say no. If the note is "we're not comfortable with that sentence," you cut it, every time.

**Consolidate your own side too.** Your partners will have opinions. Collect them into one list, make one pass, and send one version. Two rounds of notes from two sides in parallel is how a film stalls.

**Number the versions** (*v1, v2...*) and keep the approved one's email in *05\_paperwork* next to the release. When someone asks in a year whether the customer's organization approved it, the answer is a file.

**Then ask them to share it.** The customer posting your film to their own people is the referral working as intended.

## 23. AFTER IT'S LIVE

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Put it where section 1 said: the service page for that kind of work, the Google profile, the estimate email, your phone. Tell your crew it exists. Then, the next time you finish a job you're proud of, do it again — the question set, the release, the kit, the export presets, and the lower-third template are already built.

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## THE KIT, WITH REAL PRICES

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Beyond the phone you already own. Everything on this list except the two subscriptions is a one-time purchase and lasts for years.

- Tripod with a phone clamp — \$25–50
- Wireless lavalier kit with onboard backup recording — the **DJI Mic 3, two transmitters + one receiver + charging case, \$259** on DJI's US store (comes with its USB-C phone adapter; Lightning adapter sold separately for older iPhones). Two transmitters let you mic the customer and still have a spare, or a second voice. Or the Rode Wireless GO (Gen 3) — check Rode's site for the current kit and price
- Wired headphones — \$15–30
- A small dimmable LED panel with a stand — \$40–100 (only if your rooms lack a window)
- White foam board or poster board for bounce — \$5
- Gaffer tape — \$10
- A power bank or a long charging cable — \$20
- A camera app that shows audio levels and locks exposure — free (Blackmagic Camera)
- Editing software — free (iMovie, DaVinci Resolve)
- Transcription — free to \$30/month
- A music license on a business tier — \$10–30/month, only if you use music
- A second phone, tripod and clamp for the second angle — borrow them

**About \$335 to \$475, once** — the low end without the LED panel, the high end with it; the two subscriptions are on top, only if you use them.

## THE ONE-PAGE CHECKLIST

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**Before** - Placement decided; deliverable list written - Customer chosen from the reviews; asked by phone; confirmed in writing with topics, wardrobe, date, place - Organization's approver identified and yes in hand - Release signed and filed - Question set rewritten for this job - Room chosen for sound; clap test done; hum identified - Kit charged; 30 GB free; HDR off; 4K/30; Lock Camera + Lock White Balance on; Most Compatible; airplane mode plan; two angles or punch-in decided

**Shoot day** - Arrive early; frame, light, lock settings on every camera; test the mic on your own voice - Three things said out loud; "include the question in your answer" - Warm-up; the question set; follow-ups; second takes on the best three; "anything I didn't ask" - Room tone, 30 seconds - B-roll: 25–40 held shots, wide/medium/tight, the customer in the space - Name and title spelling confirmed on paper - Backed up to two places before leaving

**After** - Originals filed and untouched; every clip opens - Transcript; two highlighter passes; paper edit timed at ~200 words - Assembly; angles synced on the clap, or punch-ins placed on sentence breaks; sound leveled; room tone; music licensed or none - Lower thirds and closing card; captions corrected; safe areas respected - Color matched; SDR export - Master + per-platform exports; each watched through on its device - Private link sent with the specific question and a

date; one round; version approved and filed - Published on the service page, the Google profile, the estimate email; customer asked to share

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## **A LAST THING**

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I once had a great conversation with a plumber. I told him AI could probably tell me how to fix my plumbing problem, but it would certainly teach me I should've just called a plumber. He thought that was hilarious.

If you run a service business, you know that customer. They watched a couple videos, bought the materials, and decided they could do it themselves. Some of them pull it off. Most of them find out why your business exists.

Video's the same way. It's a craft and a service, and the kind of video in this guide isn't flashy or hip. It's good, honest, hard work that speaks for itself - which is probably how you'd describe your own work too.

Everything in here is the real job. Follow it and you'll end up with something you're proud to show people. And if you got this far and thought "I should've just called a plumber," that's what we're here for.

Thanks for reading!

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